
TikTok Really Broke Over the Weekend. We Should Just Let It Die.

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When my friends asked me why I preferred TikTok to Reels, their short-form platform of choice, I said, “My TikTok algorithm knows me better than I know myself.” With minimal “training” (watching and liking videos), I curated the perfect digital space, filled with cute animals, Broadway stars, and countless [Heated Rivalry](#) edits. It was my refuge from the horrors, my disassociation drug of choice, and, yes, everything you see on Reels was on TikTok weeks ago, so it was my way of feeling tuned into culture ahead of my friends.

Until last weekend. On Sunday, many TikTok users reported outages and glitches including the inability to upload videos and problems logging into their accounts. Users also noted that their For You Page algorithms had vastly changed and worsened. TikTok USDS, the entity formed to manage the app’s U.S. operations, posted a [statement on X](#) attributing the issues to “a power outage at one of our U.S. data centers.”

However, the timing of the outage on the same weekend as the shooting of Alex Pretti in Minneapolis, as well as the transfer of its operations to Trump-aligned ownership, raised suspicions among many users who now fear that the app they once swiped and loved may be gone for good.

My TikTok feed was selling me more random products than usual, giving me the kind of Gen Z confessionals I’d carefully pruned when I’d first gotten the app, and my precious [Hudson and Connor](#) were nowhere in sight.

I don’t have a large “following” or reach on TikTok, but I do post for fun. Just that afternoon, I’d put up a video I’d taken at the coast with a version of Taylor Swift’s “Out of the Woods” playing underneath—a popular sound that week. No views. No likes. I may be a relative nobody in cyberspace, but I usually get a few hundred views in the first hours after posting. Plus, the app kept telling me my internet was unstable. It wasn’t.

Creators I follow began posting [panicked videos](#), having their content “under review,” which hadn’t happened before, and wondering if they’re being “[shadow banned](#),” a term that means the app is censoring their content by not showing it to users who would otherwise be interested. The timing freaked people out—creators wondered if their anti-ICE or other politically left content was being censored.

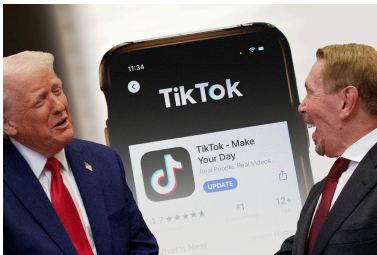
Other issues were reported as well, related to logins, comments, and other features. The combination of annoying but not malicious user experience issues and the fear of being monitored by our increasingly fascist government via the app, especially because of new terms of service that include “[precise location tracking](#),” was the perfect storm to incite rumors and fear-based action. Countless videos urged people to block Oracle, a software company whose CEO is [a close ally of Donald Trump](#) and one of the new owners, claiming it would fix the issue (it doesn’t). People began to flee TikTok, some to other similar [apps like UpScrolled](#) or YouTube, and some to parts unknown.

The chaos unfolded as TikTok in the U.S. [just changed ownership](#) to avoid being banned, and now Oracle, the United Arab Emirates investment firm MGX, and the private equity firm the Silver Lake

each have 15 percent of the company, which it shares with original parent company, ByteDance. According to Reuters, “The venture will retrain, test and update TikTok’s content recommendation algorithm on U.S. user data and the algorithm will be secured in Oracle’s U.S. cloud.” If that’s what’s happening, they’re doing a terrible job at doing so without ruining the ability to use the app.

The new regime at TikTok USDS is [blaming the issues on a power outage](#). They say they hope to “stabilize service” soon. Anecdotally, I’ve been able to “retrain” my algorithm a bit, but it’s not catching on as fast as I’ve come to expect and is still showing me things I’ve seen before or have no history of having an interest in. Most of the time when I open the app, the first video is an ad for something I don’t want or need.

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[TikTok USDS](#)’s [website](#) uses language about “content moderation,” but we cannot yet know if the fears that the changes to TikTok in the U.S. means censorship, propaganda, and other attacks on free speech are founded. However, many creators make money off of views, which the (previously) carefully curated algorithm drives, and commissions from selling via the TikTok shop—so there is an economic impact from even a small interruption to usual operations.

The [enshittification](#) of the app is perhaps temporary, but, either way, it could spell the downfall of TikTok, the way so many social media platforms fell before it. While Meta juggernaut Facebook is still around, it’s more or less a website of ads, interspersed with my dad and his boomer friends reposting one another’s political commentary. Instagram, the great millennial social network we flocked to once our parents got on Facebook, isn’t where we see what our friends ate for dinner anymore—it’s an entertainment hub, filled with short-form clips from longer press junkets, #linkinbio invitations to read articles, and spammy ads. Twitter (I will deadname Twitter until I die) is a cesspool of [A.I.-generated porn](#) occasionally interspersed with funny cultural commentary. I have no idea what the latest unifying app with the youths is, but in my household it seems to be iMessage or similar group chats filled with memes and brain rot sourced from Pinterest and YouTube.

Across all ages, social media is decentralized, with peers scattered across platforms or, if they value their mental health, opting out altogether. If the service does stabilize when the issue on TikTok’s

end is resolved, some users will have lost trust in the company, as many did when Twitter changed to X. Those who were curious about adopting the platform will not have incentive to do so. Even if everything reverts back to how we used to experience the app a week ago, the damage has been done.

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